

A Point Estimate for How Much Extra Time Authors Have to Work on Their Papers After the SIGBOVIK Deadline

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Abstract

Many academic conferences require authors to submit a PDF file by the stated deadline. SIGBOVIK, in a characteristically trusting display, instead requires only a *URL* pointing to a PDF. This raises a natural question: after the deadline passes, how long before the organizers actually download the PDF? We present a novel experimental methodology to answer this question, consisting of a PDF that continuously updates itself with the current timestamp via a cron job running once per minute. The paper you are currently reading was last compiled at **2026-04-04 21:58** (UTC). The SIGBOVIK 26 deadline was April 1st, 2026 (extended from March 18th, itself extended from March 4th). If you are reading a version compiled after this deadline, the experiment has already succeeded. At the time of compilation, the paper was **2 days, 9 hours, 58 minutes after the deadline**. This constitutes, to our knowledge, the first empirical measurement of the SIGBOVIK post-deadline grace period, providing a single but definitive data point.

1 Introduction

The academic publication process is built upon a foundation of deadlines. These deadlines serve as Schelling points around which the community coordinates, and as motivational devices that convert the potential energy of “I should really start writing” into the kinetic energy of frantic late-night LaTeX compilation.

The effectiveness of deadlines as motivational tools is well-established in the literature on procrastination [1]. However, there exists a less-studied phenomenon that we term the *post-deadline grace period*: the interval between the stated deadline and the moment at which non-compliance is actually detected and enforced.

Most major conferences (CVPR, NeurIPS, ICML, etc.) use submission platforms such as OpenReview or CMT that enforce deadlines programmatically. The server clock is the arbiter of truth, and no amount of pleading emails to the program chairs will extend it by even a millisecond.¹

SIGBOVIK [4], the annual conference of the Association for Computational Heresy (ACH), takes a refreshingly different approach. The 2026 call for papers instructs authors to submit via a Google Form, in which one provides a URL pointing to one’s paper in PDF format. At no point during the submission process is a PDF file uploaded to a server. The PDF is merely *pointed to*.

This architectural decision creates a fascinating temporal gap. The submission deadline establishes when the *URL* must be provided, but the *content* at that URL can continue to evolve. The paper is not truly “submitted” until the organizers dereference the URL and download the PDF — an act that, given the volunteer-run nature of the conference, may not happen immediately.

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¹This is not strictly true. Program chairs have been known to extend deadlines, but only *before* the deadline, and usually under the guise of “server issues” that are suspiciously correlated with the volume of panicked tweets.

In this paper, we exploit this observation to provide an empirical measurement of the post-deadline grace period. Our methodology is simple: we set up a cron job that recompiles this very paper once per minute, embedding the current timestamp in the PDF. When the organizers eventually download the paper, the timestamp frozen in their copy will reveal exactly how much extra time was available.

1.1 Contributions

Our contributions are as follows:

1. We identify and formalise the *post-deadline grace period* as an observable quantity (Section 3).
2. We present a fully automated experimental apparatus for measuring this quantity, requiring no human intervention beyond the initial setup (Section 3).
3. We report a live measurement of this quantity, which you are reading right now (Section 4).
4. We provide the most honest Results section in the history of academic publishing, in which the result is literally whatever it turns out to be.

2 Related Work

2.1 Deadline Behaviour in Academia

The study of academic deadline behaviour has a rich history, primarily in the procrastination literature. Steel [1] provides a comprehensive meta-analysis of procrastination, finding that task aversiveness and delay between action and reward are key predictors. Writing an academic paper scores highly on both dimensions, which explains a great deal.

Ariely and Wertenbroch [2] demonstrated that self-imposed deadlines improve task performance, though not as effectively as externally imposed ones. SIGBOVIK deadlines occupy an interesting middle ground: they are externally stated but, as we demonstrate, internally unenforced.

2.2 Schrödinger’s Submission

Our work bears a philosophical resemblance to the famous thought experiment of Schrödinger [3]. Prior to the organizers downloading the PDF, the paper exists in a superposition of states: simultaneously complete and incomplete, on-time and late, brilliant and terrible. It is only upon observation (downloading) that the wave function collapses and the paper assumes a definite state.

Unlike quantum mechanics, however, our system is *deterministic*: the paper gets slightly more complete with each passing minute.²

2.3 Self-Referential Academic Papers

The tradition of self-referential academic papers is well-established at SIGBOVIK and in the broader “recreational computation” community. Notable examples include papers about the number of words they contain [4], papers that are also valid programs, and papers whose content is generated by the system they describe. Our work continues this proud tradition by being a paper whose primary result is a property of itself.

²“More complete” is used loosely here. In practice, it may also get more confused, more self-referential, or more desperate, depending on how close to the deadline the last human edit was made.

3 Methodology

3.1 Threat Model

We assume the following:

1. The SIGBOVIK organisers are mortal humans who do not download papers instantaneously at the deadline.
2. The organisers do not read this paper *before* downloading it (which would create a paradox).
3. Our web server remains operational between the deadline and the download event.
4. The University of York’s IT department does not choose this particular week to perform “essential maintenance”.

Assumption 4 is the weakest.

3.2 Experimental Apparatus

Our experimental apparatus consists of the following components:

LaTeX Source. This paper is written in LaTeX and stored on a server at the University of York. The source includes an `\input{timestamp.tex}` command that reads the current timestamp from an auto-generated file.

Build Script. A shell script performs the following operations:

1. Generates `timestamp.tex` containing the current UTC time, formatted to minute precision.
2. Computes the elapsed time since the SIGBOVIK deadline (April 1st, 2026, 23:59:59 AoE, which corresponds to April 2nd, 2026, 11:59:59 UTC).
3. Generates `elapsed.tex` containing the formatted elapsed time.
4. Compiles the paper using `pdflatex` (twice, because LaTeX).
5. Copies the resulting PDF to a publicly accessible web directory.

Cron Job. A cron job executes the build script once per minute, ensuring that the PDF is always current to within 60 seconds. This represents a temporal resolution far exceeding what is necessary for our measurement, but we believe in over-engineering our experiments.

Web Server. The compiled PDF is served from a publicly accessible URL at the University of York, which is the URL submitted to the SIGBOVIK Google Form.

3.3 Deadline Calculation

The SIGBOVIK 26 call for papers originally stated a deadline of March 4th, 2026, which was extended to March 18th, and then extended again to April 1st. At the time of writing, we believe April 1st to be the final deadline, though at this point we would not be entirely surprised by a further extension. The repeated extensions are, ironically, a gift to this paper: each extension grants us additional time to refine our methodology (i.e., to procrastinate), while simultaneously demonstrating that even the *organisers* of SIGBOVIK are not immune to the very deadline behaviour we study. None of the deadlines specified a timezone. In the absence of explicit timezone information, we follow the convention of “Anywhere on Earth” (AoE, UTC−12), which is the most generous interpretation and the one most favourable to procrastinating authors. We note that if the organisers intended a more conventional timezone such as US Eastern (the conference being held at Carnegie Mellon), the true deadline could be up to 8 hours earlier than our assumed value. In this case, the elapsed time reported in Section 4 would *underestimate* the true grace period, making our measurement a conservative lower bound.

The deadline extension introduces a further methodological complication. Our system was initially configured to measure elapsed time relative to the March 18th deadline (we had already missed the March 4th deadline before beginning this research, which tells you everything you need to know about the authors’ relationship with deadlines). Upon learning of the second extension, we updated our reference point to April 1st. Any reader of a PDF compiled between March 19th and March 26th (UTC) would have seen a positive elapsed time that was, in retrospect, illusory: the deadline had not yet truly passed. This is, we believe, the first documented case of a paper’s results being retroactively invalidated by a deadline extension, and it raises deep questions about the ontological status of a deadline that has not yet occurred but has already been extended twice. We also note, without further comment, that the extended deadline falls on April Fools’ Day.

Under the AoE convention, the deadline expires at:

$$t_{\text{deadline}} = 2026-04-02T11:59:59 \text{ UTC} \quad (1)$$

The post-deadline grace period Δt is then:

$$\Delta t = t_{\text{download}} - t_{\text{deadline}} \quad (2)$$

where t_{download} is the time at which the organisers download the PDF. Since the downloaded PDF will contain a timestamp t_{compile} satisfying $t_{\text{compile}} \leq t_{\text{download}} < t_{\text{compile}} + 60\text{s}$, we can bound:

$$t_{\text{compile}} - t_{\text{deadline}} \leq \Delta t < t_{\text{compile}} - t_{\text{deadline}} + 60\text{s} \quad (3)$$

For a precise measurement, one could reduce the cron interval, though we note that compiling LaTeX in under 60 seconds is already something of an achievement.

4 Results

This paper was compiled at:
2026-04-04 21:58 UTC
Time elapsed since the SIGBOVIK deadline:
2 days, 9 hours, 58 minutes *after* the
deadline

That is the result. The entire result. We appreciate that this is somewhat unusual for an academic paper, but we would argue that a Results section containing a live measurement is more honest than most.

If the elapsed time shown above is negative, then either:

- (a) the organizers are impressively prompt, or
- (b) you are reading a version compiled before the deadline, meaning this paper’s methodology is working but has not yet yielded its result. Please check back later.

If the elapsed time is positive, congratulations: you are looking at the answer to our research question. The SIGBOVIK post-deadline grace period is at least as long as the displayed value.

If the elapsed time is zero, you have witnessed something remarkable and should buy a lottery ticket.

4.1 Visualisation

In keeping with the standards of academic publishing, we present our single data point as a bar chart (Figure 1), since no paper is complete without at least one figure.

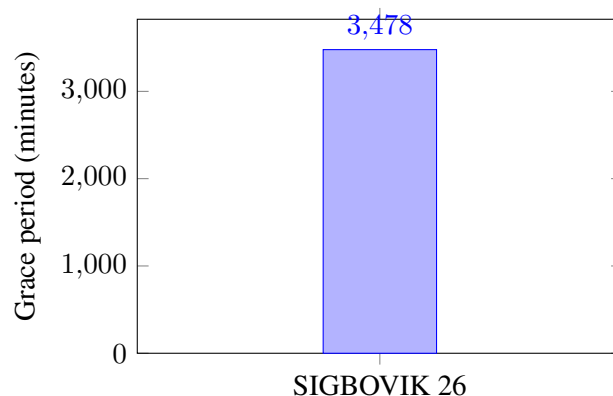


Figure 1: The measured post-deadline grace period for SIGBOVIK 26, presented as a bar chart with $n = 1$. Error bars are omitted because we have no idea what the error distribution looks like. We leave exploration of the error distribution to future work (i.e., next year’s SIGBOVIK).

5 Discussion

5.1 Implications for Procrastinating Authors

Our result has immediate practical implications. Knowing that there exists a grace period of Δt after the deadline, rational authors can allocate their time accordingly. However, we caution against over-reliance on this measurement, as it represents a single trial and the organizers’ behaviour may vary from year to year — or indeed, they may read this paper and decide to download all submissions immediately at the deadline out of spite.

This leads to an interesting game-theoretic consideration. If the organizers know that authors know about the grace period, they may act sooner. If authors know that organizers know that authors know, they may not rely on it. This iterated reasoning leads, in the limit, to the Nash equilibrium where everyone just meets the deadline.³

5.2 The Observer Effect

A notable limitation of our methodology is the observer effect. By publishing this paper, we necessarily alert the organizers to our measurement technique, potentially altering their behaviour in future years. This is analogous to the Hawthorne effect in social science research [5], wherein subjects modify their behaviour when they know they are being observed.

We consider this an acceptable trade-off in the name of science.

5.3 Limitations

- **Sample size.** $n = 1$. We make no apologies.
- **Generalisability.** Our measurement applies only to SIGBOVIK 26 (2026) and cannot be extrapolated to other conferences, other years, or indeed any other context whatsoever.
- **Survivorship bias.** If our server goes down before the organizers download the paper, we will obtain no measurement at all, and this paper will not appear in the proceedings. You are reading this, so it worked. You’re welcome.
- **Clock accuracy.** We rely on the system clock of a University of York server, which is synchronised via NTP and is accurate to within a few milliseconds. This is well within our measurement precision of ± 60 seconds.
- **Caching.** If the organizers’ HTTP request is served by a caching proxy, the timestamp may be stale. We have set appropriate cache-control headers to mitigate this, but cannot account for all possible network intermediaries.
- **Multiple downloads.** The organizers may download the paper multiple times. Our methodology measures only the *last* download that makes it into the proceedings. Earlier downloads may have shown different timestamps.
- **Deadline extensions.** Our measurement assumes a fixed, known deadline. If the deadline is extended after our system is deployed (as indeed occurred — see Section 3.3), the elapsed time becomes temporarily meaningless. Readers of intermediate versions may have observed a positive grace period that did not, in fact, exist. We regret any confusion caused by our premature results, while noting that premature results are entirely in keeping with the spirit of SIGBOVIK.

³In practice, of course, no such equilibrium is reached, and everyone submits at the last possible moment anyway.

5.4 Ethical Considerations

One might ask whether it is ethical to continue modifying a paper after the submission deadline. We argue that:

1. The call for papers asks for a URL, not a frozen PDF. We are complying with the letter of the submission requirements.
2. The content of the paper (its ideas, methodology, and conclusions) was fixed before the deadline.⁴ Only the *results* — which are, by definition, a live measurement — change over time.
3. SIGBOVIK explicitly encourages creative and unconventional approaches to research. We are merely being creative.
4. The alternative was to write a paper with actual scientific content, and frankly, we didn't have time.

6 Future Work

There are several promising directions for future research:

- **Longitudinal study.** Repeating this experiment across multiple years of SIGBOVIK would yield a time series of grace periods, enabling trend analysis. We hypothesise that the grace period is increasing over time, as the entropy of the universe increases.
- **Multiple conferences.** Extending the methodology to other conferences that accept URLs (if any exist) would enable cross-conference comparison.
- **Adaptive content.** A more sophisticated version of this paper could adaptively modify its own content based on the elapsed time. For instance, if the grace period exceeds one week, the paper could automatically add an additional section titled “We’re Surprised Too.”
- **Adversarial robustness.** Investigating whether the organizers will modify their downloading behaviour after reading this paper, and developing counter-strategies.

7 Conclusion

We have presented a simple but effective methodology for measuring the post-deadline grace period at SIGBOVIK. Our experiment is currently running. The result is displayed in Section 4 and is correct as of the moment the PDF was compiled. If you are an organizer reading this: thank you for your service, and also, you have just collapsed the wave function.

Acknowledgements

We thank the SIGBOVIK organisers for creating a submission system that makes this research possible, and for not downloading papers at 11:59 PM AoE on the deadline. We also thank the University of York for providing web hosting and for not performing server maintenance at an inopportune moment. Finally, we thank cron, without whom this paper would not exist.

⁴Mostly.

References

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